Kullu and his hometown Mandi, which is most affected by intra-party dissidence. Nadda, too, is facing trouble in his own coterie, with close confidant and Bilaspur MLA Suresh Thakur having to make way for another protégé, Trilok Jamwal.

Clearly, rebellion in the ranks, especially in their own home districts, is the last thing Nadda and the CM want before they campaign for retaining power in the state with the motto "*naya riwaz banayenge* (we'll set new traditions)". Besides anti-incumbency, CM Thakur is also facing tough questions on issues such as unemployment and downturn in businesses due to Covid-related restrictions. The factors that may work in his favour are his relatively clean image and easy accessibility, besides the popularity of central and state welfare schemes, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's continuing mass appeal and the BJP's nationalism plank.

The hill state has traditionally seen straight contests between the BJP and the Congress. In 2017, when the BJP bagged 43 of the 68 seats, the winning margin was under 3,000 votes in 20 seats, and under 1,000 in six. This time, BJP leaders hope the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) will pick up momentum and cut into Congress votes. This doesn't seem to be happening on the ground, though.

The BJP's only solace is that the Congress is also battling similar, perhaps deeper, challenges. Priyanka Gandhi is leading the campaign with the late former CM Virbhadra Singh's widow Pratibha Singh as the state chief. Pratibha Singh's chief strategist Harsh Mahajan recently switched sides and joined the BJP. Another loyalist of her family, Pawan Kajal, too, had crossed over earlier and is now the BJP candidate in Kangra. The state unit is riddled by factionalism, with various groups led by leaders such as Kuldeep Singh Rathod, Sukhwinder Singh Sukhu, Asha Kumari and Mukesh Agnihotri, besides others loyal to former Union minister Anand Sharma and veteran leader Vidya Stokes. Having learnt some lessons from Uttarakhand and Punjab, where internal feuds led to poll debacles, the Congress has so far refrained from announcing Pratibha Singh as its CM candidate in Himachal Pradesh, where it has seen back-to-back defeats in the 2014 and 2019 general elections and the 2017 assembly polls.



THE CHALLENGER Congress state chief Pratibha Singh in New Delhi for a party meeting

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THE BJP'S ONLY SOLACE IS THAT THE CONGRESS IS RIDDLED BY RAMPANT FACTIONALISM

Ashutosh Kumar, who teaches political science in Panjab University, Chandigarh, says the Congress needs to be united behind a credible face for the election campaign, but the rampant factionalism stands in the way. Given the leadership crisis, the party is finding it difficult to reach out to the electorate with its '10 guarantees'—promises like creating 500,000 jobs, providing Rs 1,500 monthly assistance to women and 300 units of free power—that were unveiled on August 31.

In the saffron camp, Union minister Anurag Thakur's father, former CM Prem Kumar Dhumal, and father-in-law Gulab Singh Thakur were denied tickets. Before his close confidant Ravinder Singh Ravi was made the BJP candidate from Jawalamukhi—instead of the sitting MLA Ramesh Dhawala, who will now contest for the Dehra seat, which Ravinder had lost the last time—Anurag had said in New Delhi that the central leadership would decide on who would be the next Himachal CM. The message to his supporters was clear. Later, on October 22, however, Anurag made another statement that Himachal will benefit with PM Modi at the Centre and CM Jai Ram Thakur in the state, giving the latter some respite.

Nadda had announced that the party would go to polls under Thakur's leadership, but the BJP has not named him as the CM candidate. Sarbananda Sonowal was replaced as Assam CM after the party won the 2020 assembly polls, but Pushkar Singh Dhami continued as Uttarakhand CM despite losing his seat. While the BJP may or may not appoint Thakur as CM on winning the Himachal polls, his current task is clearly to win over the rebels and ensure the victory of the party's candidates. ■